Piecing together the bodies of Srebrenica three decades on: the pursuit of closure, or the unearthing of old wounds?

"The pain doesn't go away, it gets worse, stronger, the longer it lasts." Fikret Bačić

A pelvic bone, a femur, a DNA match, perhaps a scrap of enduring clothing; miscellaneous pieces of an unidentifiable body. *"This is what we have found of your son, this is your husband, brother, nephew, cousin, friend."*
For almost 30 years, the search for the broken and brutalised bodies of the Srebrenica genocide of 1995, and, more widely, the victims of the Bosnian war has been underway. Each year futher bodies are uncovered, further remnants of a modern-day massacre are laid out for family members to reclaim and more remembrances of a heinous act of slaughter and ethnic cleansing come to the fore.

For, this is a massacre that weighs on the conscience of the entirety of Europe. Genocide in the EU's backyard, a preventable blood-bath that was licensed by the underestimation of the savage Bosnian Serb leader Ratko Mladić and by European refusal to act with force when force was necessary. It is what Jean-Yves Haine calls 'Europe's original sin'. And the main aftereffect of such a sin is, inevitably, a profound shame.
There is no European nation that feels this shame more greatly than the Dutch. The burden of guilt that continues to haunt the Netherlands stems from the *powerlessness* of the Dutch battalion that commandeered the UN safety zone, just on the outskirts of Srebrenica. The battalion, outnumbered, firmly instructed *not* to fire back and denied the air support that was so desperately required, was at the mercy of the Mladić's army as much as the refugees they were determined to protect. When the Serb army instigated the transportation of the refugees away from Srebrenica, the UN peacekeepers were caught an impossible position, a *jeu partie*. But this *jeopardy* would cost the lives of 8,300 men and boys carted off to town halls and abandoned schools to be exterminated en masse.

"Only one party is to blame for the horrific genocide; the Bosnian Serb army. But let me be clear. The international community failed to offer adequate protection to the people of Srebrenica and as part of that community the Dutch government shares responsibility for the situation in which that failure occurred. And for this we offer our deepest apologies," The words of the Dutch Defence Minister Kajsa Ollongren. Thus, the Dutch government shouldered some of the yoke of responsibility for the genocide. They acknowledged that they had thrown their own soldiers on the ground to the wolves, and, in so doing, exposed the Bosnian Muslims to slaughter. The Dutch government issued a gargantuan pledge as a gesture of repentance: to recover and identify *every* single Bosnian corpse and to return its family.

"The events of 1995 led to deep human suffering that is palpable here to this day. We cannot relieve you of this suffering. But what we can do is to look history straight in the eye," said Ollongren during a visit to Bosnia to commemorate the genocide. Indeed, at the moment when news of the full and bloody extent of the Srebrenica massacre reached the international stage, there was one mass grave of men and boys who had been collectively executed. Frantically, the Serbs dug out all the bodies in an attempt to cover the extent of the crime and redistributed them across 25 different sites. This made the Dutch endeavour unfathomable- they had to gather all the different, broken and scattered body parts and piece them together to return to loved ones. And yet, the Netherlands remain adamant and resolute that *every* body will be reassembled and entire corpses will be returned to families until they are happy with how much they have to bury in the Potocari memorial cemetery. Each year on the anniversary of the genocide, the Dutch government display the actual number. It is currently hovers at around ¾.

And yet, here lies the impossible impasse. The humbling question must be posed: the noble efforts of the Dutch, and the shame that drives Europe to repent for its complacency, who is it helping? It is simply an attempt to expunge a guilty conscience, or is this truly a way forward for the (predominantly female) survivors of the genocide? As so often is the case in such sensitive scenarios, there is some truth in both answers. The human needs of the veteran community are seemingly at odds.

The *justice* and *closure* that the survivors and mourners are owed can be met, in part, only by the reunion of body with family, however, not only is the process prolonged, painful and certain, but its realisation is often at the price of the reopening of old wounds, beginning to pucker into a nasty scar. The tattered and partial remains hardly do honour to the brutalised victims. In the words of a massacre survivor Fazila Efendic "There are no words to describe the sorrow you feel when you are looking for (your loved ones) bone by bone," Efendic said. "I visited every newfound mass grave; I've seen the inside of every one of them."

In other words, dredging up the bodies not only dredges up buried pain, but it is a constant and penetrating reminder to the Bosnian Muslims of their recent and bloody persecution. Their future, identity and significance as a shattered community is systematically interrupted by the callous reminder of what was, and the murders that cannot be avenged. For, no palpable or equivalent retribution exists, less could be enacted, and thus for the survivors of the trauma, moving forwards is the only option. This is not to be confused with forgetting the horrors and the suffering. It is simply a case of mitigating the trauma, learning to live with the pain and releaning how to be after such an unimaginable violation. As Fikret Bačić, another survivor

who lost his brother in the genocide, puts it: ‘The pain doesn’t go away, it gets worse, stronger, the longer it lasts.’

Plausible then, is the prospect that recovering these bodies, is simultaneously an obstacle to recovery and a necessary step towards closure in one. This paradox makes the trauma all the more fraught, actual and insurmountable. Each step forward for the Bosnian survivors is accompanied by a step back.

Thus, standing at the crossroads between memory and recovery, the community continues to suffer. The search for the bodies uncovers buried trauma; history provides little closure. On a modern front, the growing Islamophobic sentiment and rise of extremist parties across Europe weighs heavy on a people who still face the full force of Serb denial. Victims of a genocide whose neighbours will not even acknowledge them as victims.

This preventable tragedy is written on the walls of European history, and yet, its survivors are largely written out of the narrative when it comes to their recovery. The post-conflict reverberations of Srebrenica continue to shake a vulnerable people, and illuminate the multiple fault lines that zigzag their way across Europe. The echo chamber remains, tragically, replete with echoes. The name Srebrenica must not be an echo that loses its auditory force. That is the duty owed to both its victims and survivors.